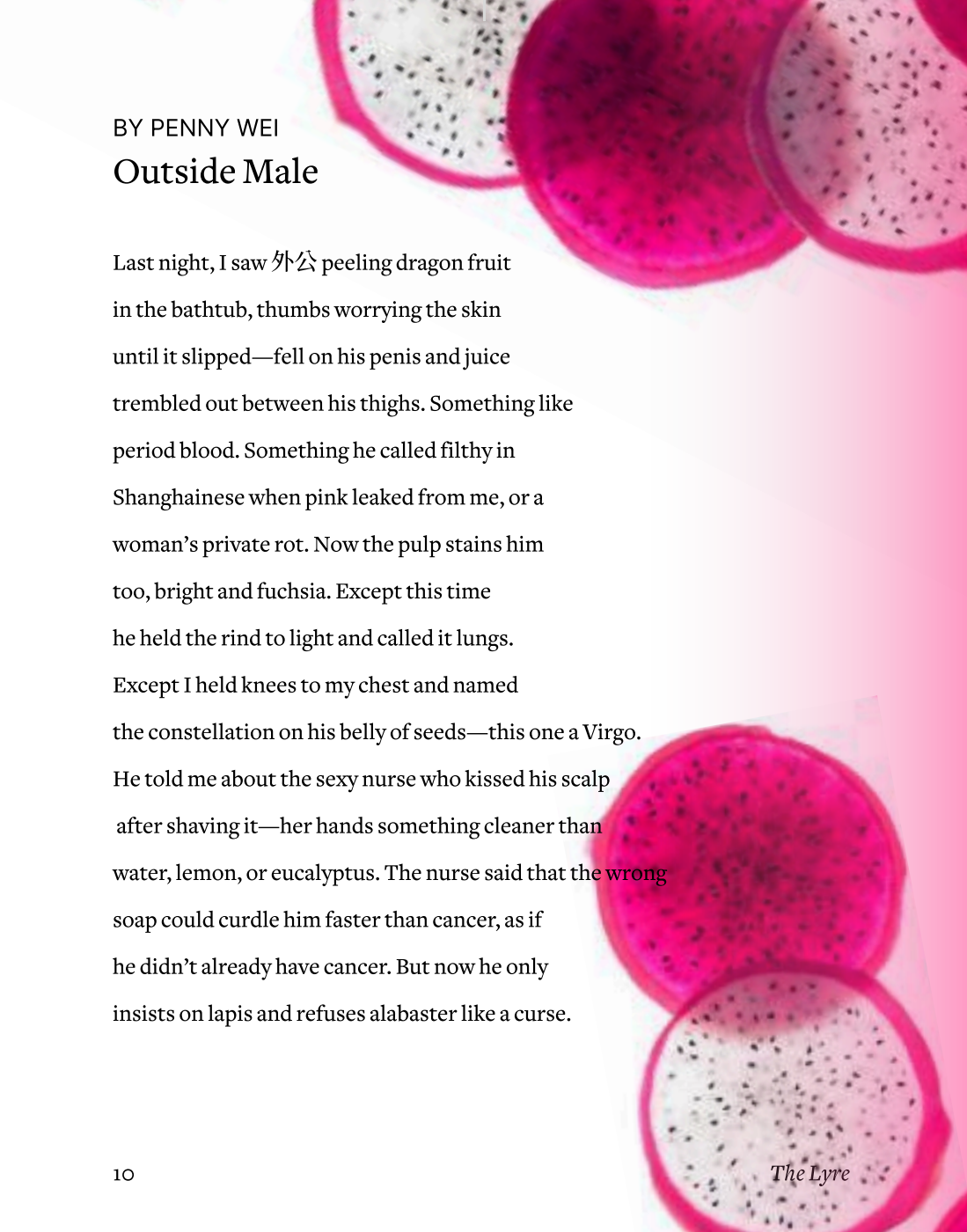




BY PENNY WEI

## Outside Male

Last night, I saw 外公 peeling dragon fruit  
in the bathtub, thumbs worrying the skin  
until it slipped—fell on his penis and juice  
trembled out between his thighs. Something like  
period blood. Something he called filthy in  
Shanghainese when pink leaked from me, or a  
woman's private rot. Now the pulp stains him  
too, bright and fuchsia. Except this time  
he held the rind to light and called it lungs.  
Except I held knees to my chest and named  
the constellation on his belly of seeds—this one a Virgo.  
He told me about the sexy nurse who kissed his scalp  
after shaving it—her hands something cleaner than  
water, lemon, or eucalyptus. The nurse said that the wrong  
soap could curdle him faster than cancer, as if  
he didn't already have cancer. But now he only  
insists on lapis and refuses alabaster like a curse.